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CRIME AND ROMANCE

A Murder Mystery, Robbers and Rail Romance

Crime and romance added to the colourful history of the railways in India. This chapter will narrate a few interesting incidents of this nature.

THE SEVEN TYPES OF RAIL ROBBERS IN INDIA

Did you know that there were categories of robbers and criminals on the railways? Well, an interesting work mainly sourced from verbal and documentary information and published in 1909 by Hargrave Lee Adam, a crime writer from the early twentieth century, gives elaborate details about this.

The book is based purely on information from people who have dealt with criminals in the east. The author goes on to write in the first chapter itself that criminals in India are far better than those in the west. Their greatest vice is, he says, craft, and that a vast amount of crime committed in India is hereditary, with those committing it not realizing many a time that it is an offence. Adam's work categorizes the railway thieves into seven classes and starts by saying, 'There are, in India, as in this country, what may be termed "specialities" in crime, and the railway thief of India, like the coiner in this country, confines his depredations exclusively to that one form of crime.' He further warns: 'The railway thieves of India are among the most astute, secretive, skilful, and difficult to detect of Indian criminals.' [110]